

How to Write a Research Paper in Psychology? A Winner's Guide

"If we knew what it was, we were doing, it would not be called research, would it?"

– Albert Einstein

When it comes to research in psychology, there is more to it than just writing a well-structured piece of literature. Also, as a student, you won't just be dealing with research papers but also academic assignments, articles, etc. However, it is important to have the fundamentals of writing a good research paper clear. This way, you will have the required skills to write any research-related assignment in psychology.

It can be hard for students to write a research paper as novices, so through this blog article, you will get a fair idea about how to go about writing a quality research paper.

8 Easy steps to write a perfect research paper in Psychology

When it comes to research, universities have their own structure and format that they expect the students to follow. The formats followed by universities may vary a little but the basics remain in line with the APA's (American Psychological Association) format. It would be wise to go through the APA format while comparing it with your university's format. Here are a few things that are integral to a quality research paper:

1. **Choosing the right topic for research-** The first step is always tough, be it anything, so this might look challenging but guess what? By identifying where your interest lies, you can land yourself a good research topic. When you are writing a psychology research paper a lot depends on you makes your curiosity tickle. Make sure you have enough time to decide your topic because you will have to check the material available that you can work with. Sometimes, your topic could be too narrow and you might find yourself at a dead end. Discuss the topic with your professors and peers to get different perspectives into the picture.
2. **Collect your research pool-** While having enough time at hand is crucial to good research appear, it is important that you use this time to gather all the research material you can find from various sources. Start with authentic sources like books, and journal articles, and then you can finally go to online sources as much of the content is easily available by a tap on the screen. Keep in mind the credibility of the content while dealing with differentiating historical data and recent information. Use the right research method to browse old collected data and modern literature that matches your research topic. Save them as separate folders on your phone or laptop so that it easily accessible to you to review.
3. **Choose your sources wisely-** Following the previous instruction, choosing the right kind of resources is also highly important. A research paper requires dozens of researches but the quality of research also matters. Say, you go through 15 articles just to find out your topic is something else altogether. What must one do to get the resources right? Well, some researchers suggest that one must start with peer-reviewed articles and analysis articles. Also, this stage is used to understand the topic on a basic level if you are choosing a completely new topic. Ensure you have a clear picture of the tenure you want to include, so if you go through the last 5 years of any topic being discussed, it can narrow down your

material to specific developments. With the onset of various recent stressors like COVID-19, working from home, going back to work, etc, ensure you include the updated status of the impact of these factors on your research topic. Some popular and reliable research platforms for psychology include APA, Psychology Today, and Science Daily.

4. **Formulate a thesis statement-** The entire basis of your research paper will depend on this step. Formulating a hypothesis is your goal or statement of purpose on which the entire research paper is going to revolve around. This is the centerpiece of your research article, so, ensure you have it right. A thesis statement can be anything from a hypothesis or simply a research statement that captures the essence of what you wish to convey through your paper. This step will streamline your work and help you navigate through the course of writing the paper.
5. **Make a research paper outline-** It can be difficult to frame an outline for your research paper when you haven't actually organised your content or gone through them in its entirety. Sorting out your notes as questions and sub-topics can be useful. This will help you structure your paper and give it a shape that can be followed by the readers. Keep in mind that your research paper mainly contains three parts, the introduction, and hypothesis, the body, and the conclusion. Start by filling the gaps between these headings and make a constructive framework for yourself. If you are in the higher levels of academics, you will also have an abstract, a proposal, or a discussion section for your work, therefore, it will vary on that front as well. To avoid overlapping subheads, go through the instruction given by your organisation while following the guiding steps to write an effective research paper. Go through the internet for samples and choose the one that will best justify your topic.
6. **Stay structured and organised with the material and method-** Once you have the required material you need, it is advisable to organise them as much as you can. You will learn how to keep the paper structured by inculcating the habit of staying organised through each stage. While methods can be simply followed keeping in mind the objectives, when it comes to content, you might have to analyse your data multiple times. As to the quality, tweak out the stuff you don't require, keep it to the point, avoid plagiarism, always cite your references and be accurate while quoting famous personalities. Quantity can be worked on by dividing the content into the outline you made and further organising them into literature worth reading.
7. **Start drafting-** Now comes the inevitable step. All the effort you have put into your research paper will bear fruit only if you start writing your thoughts and opinions in simple, easily understandable yet vocabulary-rich words. A draft will allow you to conserve the ideas you have had all through the stages. This way you will not ignore writing until the very last minute and have enough time to dedicate to making multiple drafts of your research paper. Psychology is all about different perspectives, so passing on your rough drafts for suggestions from peers will be a huge plus for you!
8. **MOST IMPORTANT: Final Editing and re-editing-** The final stage is the editing and of course, re-editing until you have the final one. Not only is this very important but is also the time when you look for every wrong comma and misspelled word. However, editing may also include changing a few ideas while you are at it. Having re-read your work so many times; you may have a change of thought or realise an enhancement you wish to include. Working on those shortcomings and questions will refine your content most productively.

Getting your paper reviewed by a few of your friends can be game-changing, let your work be viewed by a different pair of eyes, they might just point out what you overlooked. Naturally, the process of a writing research paper is tedious and exhausting and sometimes you blank out! During those times, just take a step back, get some sleep and review your progress with a fresh mind. Also, keep a notepad at your bedside to note down those brilliant midnight ideas. You never know when the right thing will hit you, so make sure you have it to work on later.

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